

What else to watch: *The General* (1926) ■ *Little Women* (1933) ■ *A Streetcar Named Desire* (1951, pp.116–17) ■ *Cold Mountain* (2003) ■ *12 Years a Slave* (2013)

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A landmark in movie history, and only the very blasé can say of it that frankly they don't give a damn.

Philip French
The Observer, 2010

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was out, producer David O. Selznick had committed to making the movie version. It was a gargantuan task. The draft screenplay ran to six hours and took four writers to edit. It is said that 1,400 unknowns and dozens of stars were seen for the role of its heroine, Scarlett O'Hara. Having waited a year for actor Clark Gable to be free, Selznick then fired director George Cukor just three weeks into filming and replaced him with Victor Fleming.

Love, loss, and longing

The movie is, at heart, a love triangle writ large: Scarlett (Vivien Leigh) is in love with Ashley Wilkes (Leslie Howard), who is engaged to marry his cousin. On the rebound she catches the eye of Rhett Butler (Clark Gable). The violence of war aptly reflects the tortured love affair between Rhett and Scarlett, captured in stunning Technicolor by cinematographer Ernest Haller.

The movie's depiction of, and open nostalgia for, the slave-based society of the Old South betrays many questionable assumptions, but some of the

novel's more openly racist passages are simply sidestepped. Hattie McDaniel, who played Scarlett's house slave Mammy, won one of the movie's 10 Oscars—the first African-American to be so honored.

Ultimately this is Scarlett's story. While the movie ends with her alone, undone by her own selfishness, it is also a metaphor for America as a land of hope and regeneration. Although she is rebuffed by Rhett, who shuns her desperate pleas for reconciliation with a curt, “Frankly, my dear, I don't give a damn,” the last line of the movie belongs to Scarlett. “I'll go home,” she says, thinking of her home at Tara, her family, and her roots, “and I'll think of some way to get him back. After all... tomorrow is another day.” ■



Vivien Leigh Actress

Born in Darjeeling, India, in 1913, Vivien Leigh shot to international fame with *Gone with the Wind*, becoming the first British actress to win a Best Actress Oscar. She was equally accomplished on stage and on screen, and won her second Oscar for playing Blanche DuBois in *A Streetcar Named Desire*, a role she had

first played in the theater. Described by director George Cukor as “a consummate actress, hampered by beauty,” Leigh had a troubled private life; her fragile mental and physical health resulted in a limited output. She succumbed to tuberculosis in 1967, and died at 53.

Key movies

1939 *Gone with the Wind*
1951 *A Streetcar Named Desire*

The movie's premiere in 1939 in Atlanta, Georgia, drew one million people to the city. This poster dates to 1967, when the movie was rereleased in a wide-screen print.